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KNOWLEDGE OF GOD IN BERNARD LONERGAN AND HANS KÜNG

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Can the existence of God be rationally demonstrated? This question has occupied philosophers and theologians for centuries and in a particular way since Kant's *Critique of Pure Reason*. This essay will examine the question of the knowledge of God as it is met by two contemporary Catholic theologians, Bernard Lonergan and Hans Küng. These two scholars are not chosen arbitrarily for comparison. Not only is each of them on the forefront of current theological development, but I shall argue that on the question of God the ambitious, but ultimately unsuccessful, efforts of the former are significantly complemented by the latter.

Lonergan has been justly celebrated for his pioneering work in theological method. But in *Method in Theology*¹ one finds no argument for the existence of God. Such an argument can be found in Lonergan's earlier foundational philosophical work *Insight: A Study of Human Understanding*.² This argument has met with very severe criticism. Lonergan has countered these challenges by briefly referring to his developing reflections concerning the fourth level of human consciousness, the existential subject, horizon, historical consciousness, the shift from classical culture to modern culture and his protean notion of conversion. Nevertheless, Lonergan himself has not turned to the reworking of his argument. If, however, we turn to Hans Küng's *On Being a Christian*³ we find a philosophy of God that, while less rigorous than Lonergan's work, might serve as an instance of thematized fourth level operations. This essay, therefore, will be in five parts: 1) Lonergan's argument for the existence of God, 2) the criticism, 3) Lonergan's

¹ *Method in Theology* (New York: Herder & Herder, 1972). To be sure the whole of part 1, "Background," in treating of feelings, values, beliefs, the human good, meaning, religious experience and the question of God and the discussion of conversion, as well as the discussion of the theoretical, systematic and transcendent exigencies of differentiated polymorphic consciousness in part 2, "Foreground," serve as a propaedeutic for exposing the horizon within which God is apprehended. A critical argument for the existence of God is conspicuously absent. Cf., e.g., pp. 101–24.

² *Insight: A Study of Human Understanding* (London: Longmans, Green & Co., 1965).

response and the new position on God, 4) Hans Küng's position on knowledge of God, and 5) conclusions.

I. Lonergan's Argument for the Existence of God

In *Insight* Lonergan elaborates his cognitional theory by inviting the reader to performance. That performance is the self-affirmation of the subject as a knower. Consequent upon the affirmation of that fact is the possible thematization of human consciousness as a dynamic, self-assembling, recurrent structure with three compenetrating "levels." First there is the level of experience. Here one is confronted by the random data of the world as a whole. Second, there is the level of understanding. Here emerge questions for intelligence (e.g., what is it?) and hypotheses are formulated. Third, there is the level of judgment. Here emerge questions for reflection (e.g., is it so?). Evidence is marshalled and weighed and the judgment is made in the grasp of the virtually unconditioned (a conditioned whose conditions, as a matter of fact, have been fulfilled). Unquestionably Lonergan's argument for the existence of God is focused upon this third level.⁴ In spite of their obvious interrelatedness an interval of nearly twenty years separates *Insight* from *Method*. Lonergan's post-*Insight* reading of existentialism and phenomenology led to his gradually speaking of yet a fourth level of consciousness. This is the level of commitment and decision. Here emerge questions of value (e.g., is it worthwhile?). Here affect and feeling lead to the self-involvement of the existential subject moving him or her from words and ideas to commitments and deeds.

With this background we may turn directly to the argument. For the Lonergan of *Insight*, if we are to talk of God we must move from proportionate to transcendent being. Being is whatever may be intelligently grasped and reasonably affirmed. Proportionate being lies within the domain of man's inner or outer experience. One has knowledge of the transcendent only when one can intelligently grasp and reasonably affirm transcendent being. After an exacting examination of causality Lonergan concludes his extrapolation from proportionate to transcendent being stating:

Every proportionate being is in its every aspect a virtually unconditioned. As a matter of fact, it is, and so it is unconditioned. But it is unconditioned not formally in the sense that it has no conditions whatever, but only virtually in the sense that its conditions happen to be fulfilled. To regard that happening as ultimate is to affirm the mere matter of fact as ultimate without any explanation. To account for one

⁴For an elaboration of this cognitional theory see Lonergan's "Cognitional Structure" in *Collection: Papers by Bernard Lonergan* (ed. Frederick Crowe; New York: Herder & Herder, 1967) 211-37.

happening by appealing to another is to change the topic without meeting the issue, for if the other happening is regarded as mere matter of fact without any explanation then either it is not being or else being is not the intelligible.⁵

While rejecting the ontological arguments of Anselm and Descartes, since conception alone is not adequate ground for affirmation, Lonergan warns that conceivability is not to be replaced with experience. For we do not experience God directly. What must be added is the grasp of the virtually unconditioned. The virtually unconditioned consists in inferring God's existence from premises that are true.

So for Lonergan, the existence of God is known as the conclusion to an argument. And though the arguments are many, Lonergan states them in one general form:

If the real is completely intelligible, God exists. But the real is completely intelligible, therefore, God exists.

The minor premise rests on the complete identity of the real and being. As the object of the detached, disinterested unrestricted desire to know, being must be completely intelligible. For this desire only comes to its goal, which is being, when every intelligent question has been given an intelligent answer, and that answer has been found to be correct. Again being is the intelligible. It is what is known in correct understanding. It is completely intelligible because being is known completely only when all intelligent questions are raised and answered correctly.

Lonergan argues: if the real is completely intelligible, then complete intelligibility exists. But if complete intelligibility exists, then the idea of being exists. Earlier, Lonergan has distinguished between notion (anticipatory and heuristic) and idea (grasped and understood). If all intelligent questions cannot be answered correctly then you have only the heuristic notion of being. But that is to render some dimension of the universe as random, mere matter of fact, unintelligible, without explanation. But the eros of the mind to know requires that all intelligent questions be not only raised but correctly answered. Therefore the idea of being does exist, and so God exists. For the idea of being could exist only in one who completely grasps and understands being, because in understanding himself he apprehends the correct answers to all intelligent questions.

The argument, which can only be given in outline,⁶ presumes that one has been following the moving viewpoint of Lonergan closely in his pursuit of intelligibility over the vast terrain of *Insight*: from the early

⁵*Insight*, 654.

⁶For the complete argument see *Insight*, 634–86, and Bernard Tyrrell *Bernard Lonergan's Philosophy of God* (Dublin: Gill and Macmillan, 1974).

examples of mathematics through physics, natural science, common sense, cognitional theory, epistemology and the metaphysics of proportionate being and the final extrapolation to transcendent being. It further presumes that one has remained faithful to Lonergan's position on knowledge, objectivity, being and the real. But several times Lonergan expressed the same *caveat*. The proof is not automatic. It is not the same as taking an aspirin to relieve a headache. All that he can do is set down a set of signs on the pages. The signs represent a relevant virtually unconditioned. But to grasp this and make the consequent judgment is an immanent act of rational consciousness that everyone must perform for oneself. Such a performance will lead to the affirmation that the ultimate is an infinite act of intelligence understanding everything about everything. Therefore, *ipsum intelligere* is logically prior to *ipsum esse subsistens*.

II. The Criticisms

Lonergan's argument for the existence of God is problematic and has been severely criticized. The criticisms center on the argument's critical assertion that the real is completely intelligible. The objection can be put in either of two ways: (1) The real is not completely intelligible for we must distinguish the intelligibility immanent "in" reality from that intelligibility projected by the knower "onto" reality. This argument in Lonergan's view is to embrace the counter-position on knowledge and the nature of the real. Nevertheless, not a few hold this counter-position, including many scientists. (2) The real may in fact be completely intelligible but only God in reflection upon Himself can grasp that intelligibility. But the real is not completely intelligible *for man*. Hence man cannot rationally demonstrate the existence of God since he has no bridge from his experience of proximate intelligibility to his hoped for ultimate intelligibility. To claim complete intelligibility is to import the principle of sufficient reason from Greek metaphysics which is no longer considered self-evident.

James Albertson states the basic form of several objections to Lonergan's position that the real is completely intelligible. He argues that Lonergan must grant

. . . a distinction between those intelligibilities immanent in the objects and patterns of experience, and those intelligibilities projected by the knower into objects and patterns of experience.⁷

Albertson agrees with Lonergan that within human experience there are necessities, unities, and relations which contain an immanent and

⁷James Albertson, "Review of *Insight*," *The Modern Schoolman* 35 (1957-58) 238.

intrinsic intelligibility. But, besides these, human experience also encounters regularity, separateness and sequence. However, the methodology of contemporary physics allows for the conversion of these latter into the former by means of mathematical theory. In this case, necessity, unity, and relation are imposed upon experience. They are intelligibilities projected upon reality as distinguished from immanent intelligibilities.

In his study on "*Method and Insight*," Ronald Hepburn takes the question further by asking if Lonergan has really shown being to be fully intelligible. By showing how one moves from the lower to the higher viewpoints in science, Lonergan has indicated to Hepburn's satisfaction that what appears chaotic from a lower viewpoint attains an intelligibility from a higher viewpoint. But he is not convinced that this is or must be so for all being. It is one thing to desire complete intelligibility; it is another to claim that such is the case. A limited intelligibility would be sufficient to ground our intellectual achievements. It is possible that not everything is knowable. Some data may escape explanation from even the highest viewpoint.⁸

Looking at Lonergan's argument from the viewpoint of the theology of hope, J. P. Mackey argues that we cannot say that being is completely intelligible. It is partially intelligible and there is hope it will be intelligible in the future. More than being given, the intelligibility of being is in the making. According to Mackey, Lonergan insists on total intelligibility here and now even if it is not available to the individual. This insistence follows upon a Platonic idea of God as total truth, immutable exemplar of a universe potentially intelligible to a mind that transcendently extrapolates from the imperfect material of intramundane experience. But from the empirical universe we can at best have cause to entrust ourselves to some indefinable ground of being. "That entrusting perhaps makes our world seem more kin to us, more hopeful (is that the same as saying 'more intelligible?')." ⁹

Perhaps the most formidable challenge to Lonergan's argument for the complete intelligibility of the real comes from David Burrell. Granting the identification of the real with being, Burrell states that being is an inherently heuristic notion. For it is the objective of an unrestricted but uncompleted desire to understand. What could be the meaning of "complete intelligibility" in this context? Being would no longer be heuristic, no longer the objective of an unrestricted desire to know. It would become the object and content of an unrestricted act of

⁸Ronald Hepburn, "*Method and Insight*," *Journal of the Royal Institute of Philosophy* 48 (1975) 153-60.

⁹J. P. Mackey, "Divine Revelation and Lonergan's Transcendental Method in Theology," *Irish Theological Quarterly* 40 (1973) 7.

understanding. But we have no experience of any such act in any pattern of experience. Therefore, it is impossible to affirm being as completely intelligible because the kind of judgment necessary to affirm that all intelligent questions were raised and correctly answered is inconceivable.

Further, Burrell is sceptical regarding Lonergan's extrapolation from restricted acts of understanding to an unrestricted act, from the notion to the idea of being, because of the way in which Lonergan describes this unrestricted act of understanding. Lonergan says that this act insofar as it understands itself grasps everything about everything in a single view. It is the eternal rapture glimpsed in every cry of Eureka. But Burrell says that this is not possible, and hence Lonergan's theistic argument cannot be completed:

Any experience we have of understanding truly is had through a specific judgment. We can understand what it means to truly understand by reflecting on what happens when we affirm that something is the case. But we cannot, I submit, understand what it is to grasp reality outside of a judgment—"in a single view." Hence we cannot understand what it means to say that being is completely intelligible.¹⁰

It is obvious that if the meaning of being as "completely intelligible" cannot be understood, then no affirmation about "complete intelligibility" can be made, certainly not its existence. But if such an affirmation is not possible, then Lonergan's argument cannot be completed. While the argument is not conclusive, this does not mean that its cumulative force does not make a belief in God more plausible. But as it stands, chapter 19 betrays the authentic movement of the rest of *Insight* precisely because it attempts to translate the vision of all things ordered to God's glory into an argument.

III. Lonergan's Response and New Position

The entire dialectic process of Lonergan's work pivots on his idea that positions invite development and counter-positions invite reversal. His positions on knowledge and being are foundational for the forward movement of his theistic argument. Initially, Lonergan considered the above objections to be unfaithful to the positions presupposed by the theistic argument and embracing the counter-position that the argument opposes. For example, responding directly to Burrell's criticism, Lonergan distinguishes knowing from intending. When we ask questions we do not have answers, but we do intend answers. And we recognize the correct answers when we uncover them. Because of the

¹⁰David Burrell, "How Complete Can Intelligibility Be? A Commentary on *Insight*: Chapter XIX," *The American Catholic Philosophical Association Proceedings for the Year 1967* (Washington: Catholic University of America, 1967) 252.

movement from experience, to understanding and judgment, coming to know is a process. And this process is intentional. But this process rejects all obscurantism and raises every question. Hence, our intending intends not incomplete but complete intelligibility. If intending intended only incomplete intelligibility, that would mean that there was a point when further questions could arise but did not. But further questions continue to arise because of the unbounded dynamism of human inquiry. Lonergan agrees with Burrell that we have no immediate knowledge of complete intelligibility since we have no immediate knowledge of God, but this complete intelligibility remains the objective of our intending and meaning. It is the condition of possibility of all our individual acts of intending. Hence, Lonergan argues that if one is faithful to his position on the isomorphism that obtains between knowing and the known and his distinction between understanding that is grasped and understanding that is intended, then indeed his argument can be completed.¹¹

Bernard Tyrrell correctly stresses that for Lonergan the critical element leading to the formal theistic proof is the cumulative process that first identifies the real with being, second, identifies being with complete intelligibility, and finally, identifies complete intelligibility with the unrestricted act of understanding that possesses the properties of God. Further, this process is possible only if one remains completely faithful to the intellectual pattern of experience and the exigencies of the pure desire to know. There can be no tolerance for obscurantism and there must be a full commitment to the basic positions.

In examining the objections of Albertson, Hepburn and Burrell, Tyrrell rightly points to where they depart from the basic positions. But since the positions are the presuppositions of the argument—indeed, in my judgment, they *are* the argument in embryo—one cannot come to any other conclusion but Lonergan's if one is faithful to them. I do not believe that Lonergan has successfully confronted the objections concerning the extrapolation from partial to complete intelligibility. But perhaps such a confrontation is not necessary in the light of Lonergan's new position on his theistic argument.

Lonergan's new position is basically a recognition of the impact of his post-*Insight* reflections on the fourth level of consciousness upon his theistic argument.¹² Now the apprehension of value takes precedent

¹¹See "Theories of Inquiry: Responses to a Symposium" in *A Second Collection: Papers by Bernard J. Lonergan, S.J.* (ed. William Ryan and Bernard Tyrrell; London: Gaston, Longman & Todd, 1974) 40–42.

¹²For astute observations on the implicit influence of "fourth level" experiences in the theistic argument of *Insight* see Jon Nelson, "Transcendent Knowledge of *Insight*: a Closer Look," *The Thomist* 37 (April 1973) 566–77.

over the grasp of a virtually unconditioned. In an interview with Phillip McShain he concedes that chapter 19 of *Insight* is the product of an entirely different kind of thinking than is being built up by the rest of the book, and he says, "I'd be quite ready to say: Let's drop Chapter XIX out of *Insight* and put it inside of theology."¹³ He continues to hold that there exists a valid proof of the existence of God and that the apprehension of that proof is not a supernatural act *quoad substantiam*. However, he paradoxically observes that those who do apprehend that proof have God's grace. With Vatican I he defends the *possibility* of a theistic proof but not the reality. In Lonergan's opinion the main incongruity between chapter 19 and the rest of *Insight* is that while his cognitional theory arises from a long and methodological appeal to experience, there is no parallel appeal to religious experience in his theistic argument. Once you consider the concrete individual you must consider his horizon, his world view, his value perception, the affect-laden images and symbols that are the carriers of the multi-dimensional meanings that are constitutive of his community, and the degree to which polymorphic human consciousness has or has not been differentiated within his particular culture. The traditional Catholic position does not give sufficient attention to differences within each subject.

With this turn to the concrete, historical subject, religious conversion, not proof, becomes the center of the God question. Lonergan concedes that proofs are usually the work of believers who wish to provide foundations in reason for the faith they already profess. They do not vainly seek to demonstrate rationally their faith; they simply seek to indicate that it is a reasonable commitment. While it is possible to experience religious conversion while reasoning about the God hypothesis, this is the exception. If the presence of conversion in the process of coming to know God is overlooked, in favor of proofs, then there exists the danger of lapsing into an abstract, non-existential mode of envisaging reality.¹⁴

From his new vantage point Lonergan argues that natural theology (better termed philosophy of God), once perhaps rightly separated from the functional specialty, systematics, should be seen as a distinct but integral part of systematic theology. Obviously only those persons who consider it of value will seriously reflect on the question of God. It matters not if one is a philosopher or a theologian reflecting on God, it is the same God that is being affirmed as value. However, while it might be inappropriate to expect philosophers in a philosophy department to

¹³Phillip McShane, "An interview with Fr. Bernard Lonergan, S.J.," in *A Second Collection*, 224.

¹⁴See Tyrrell, *Lonergan's Philosophy of God*, 118–19.

reflect on the specifically Christian religious experience, there is no difficulty in expecting theologians in a theology department to reflect on the specifically Christian religious experience. Hence, Lonergan concludes that it is the theologian who can explain why the God of the philosophers and the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob are the same God.¹⁵

I must conclude that for the present there is an unresolved tension in Lonergan's position. He clearly sees the inadequacy of his earlier theistic argument. Yet he is unwilling to yield completely his challengingly rigorous "natural theology" to the full implications of his current emphasis upon the pivotal significance of religious conversion and the fourth level of human consciousness. I suspect that the reason for this tension is that Lonergan does not wish the "objectivity" of his earlier argument to give way to the "mere subjectivity" of even the religiously converted subject. Perhaps a partial resolution may be found in Lonergan's assertion that true objectivity is the achievement of authentic subjectivity. But for the implications of this we must turn to Hans Küng.

IV. Hans Küng's Position on the Knowledge of God

Hans Küng's lengthy recent work, *On Being a Christian*, may be seen as at once an instance of Lonergan's theological method and of David Tracy's "revisionist" model of theology.¹⁶ In spite of the fact that, as the work of one man, Küng's work may appear at first to be an example of the kind of "totalitarian ambition" which Lonergan abhors, it does in fact fully appreciate the division of labor and the functional specialties that Lonergan calls for. Essentially, *On Being a Christian* is an example of Lonergan's fifth functional specialty, foundations.¹⁷ As a revisionist rather than an orthodox theologian, Küng is not restrained by previous formulations from bold reinterpretations of commonly held beliefs. And as one seeking to establish the foundational horizon for broad ecumenical dialogue Küng is free not to address certain specific Roman

¹⁵See Bernard Lonergan, *Philosophy of God and Theology: The Relationship Between Philosophy of God and the Functional Specialty, Systematics* (London: Gaston, Longman & Todd, 1973) 45–59.

¹⁶See *Blessed Rage for Order: the New Pluralism in Theology* (New York: Seabury, 1975). Tracy argues that in the present pluralistic context five basic models of theology can be discerned: orthodox, liberal, neo-orthodox, radical and revisionist. In the revisionist model the basic meaning of the Christian tradition and the general scientific world view of secularity are both embraced dialectically with an understanding that one can "revise" the other when either fails to meet certain critically grounded criteria.

¹⁷There are, in all, eight "functional specialties," four of which mediate the meaning of past tradition: research, interpretation, history, dialectic; and four which mediate that meaning to the present situation: foundations, doctrines, systematics and communications.

Catholic questions that would be required were he undertaking the sixth functional specialty, doctrines. Further, when turning to questions of scripture, Küng clearly acknowledges his dependence on yet another specialty, interpretation, and faithfully documents the exegetes whose opinion he is following. Perhaps most importantly he is acutely aware of Lonergan's final and often overlooked specialty, communications. Unmistakably, Küng wishes to communicate with a larger audience than his fellow scholars. His readable style as well as the ease with which he cites *Time* along with technical materials is a part of his effort to communicate with contemporary men and women in their actual situations.

There is a sense in which this entire work is developed within the existential and concrete parameters of Lonergan's fourth level of human consciousness. This is graphically clear in the work's original German title, *Christ Sein*. This perspective is clearly the controlling factor of his phenomenological argument for the existence of God.

After elaborating the inadequacy of technological evolution and politico-social revolution for the fulfillment of man's transcendent longings, Küng turns directly to the question of God. Like Lonergan he rejects all forms of the ontological argument. But when he comes to the cosmological and teleological arguments (which in refined forms become Lonergan's ultimate intelligibility) he in effect denies Lonergan's extrapolation from proportionate to transcendent being. He doubts that the move from the visible to the invisible is a successful one, for the ultimate cause reached by *a posteriori* arguments may be identifiable with the individual, society's self-understanding or the material universe. Further these arguments cannot exclude an infinite regression with absolute certainty.

Küng agrees with Kant's *Critique of Pure Reason* in its argument that the existence of God cannot be demonstrated or refuted by theoretical reason alone. He does not wish, however, to share Kant's point of departure. He does not want to postulate God as the condition of the possibility for morality and happiness that can be known only to practical reason. Küng wants to start from a wider existential consideration of the individual human person. He suggests that we start with the whole reality of the world as we concretely experience it and then inquire about the condition of the possibility of this wholly and entirely uncertain reality. He has no intention of deducing the reality of God by a process of syllogistic reasoning. Instead he wishes to thematize dimensions of experience available to all human beings so that one can make a rationally responsible decision which is not compelling because of pure reason alone. It is compelling because it engages the whole person. Küng envisions a fully practical function of reason which is a

“meditative reflection, accompanying, opening up, elucidating the concrete experience of reality.”¹⁸ Küng’s starting point for the question of God is therefore not rational argument but the horizon of the fourth level of consciousness in the existential subjects as they encounter reality. Küng offers a notably unmetaphysical preliminary description of God as “the mysterious and unshakable ground of what is—despite everything—a meaningful life; the center and depth of man, of human fellowship, of reality as a whole, the final supreme authority on which everything depends; the Opposite, beyond our control, source of our responsibility.”¹⁹

Protesting that he does not wish to add to the list of rational “proofs” of God’s existence, Küng divides his argument into two main parts: the first is the hypothesis of God and the second is the reality of God.

Continuing his reliance upon Kant, Küng argues that the ultimate questions are questions about truth, norms and meaning. And it is these very questions that turn one at least to the hypothesis of God. But if the hypothesis of God is to be formulated there is a crucial *assumption*. This assumption is that one does not regard uncertain reality and one’s own existence as *a priori* meaningless and vain. One must, in spite of uncertainty, regard reality as valuable and meaningful at least in principle. This existential posture before reality grounds a fundamental trust and confidence. This assumption is critical because it is precisely what Lonergan refused to assume in *Insight*. It is what he set out to ground and demonstrate critically in his advance to the complete intelligibility of the real. The only reason that it can be assumed, even hypothetically, however, is certain seemingly self-authenticating experiences on the fourth level of consciousness that evaluate polyvalent reality as meaningful.

While the experience of reality as a whole invites a response of basic trust, in Küng’s opinion reality itself remains ambiguous, mysteriously unsubstantiated, sustaining yet not sustained, evolving but to no purpose. But what is the condition of possibility of such a reality?

Küng responds with his hypothesis. If there were a God, would not all agree that reality would have a primal reason, primal goal, primal ground for its being? Further, if there were a God, would not one be justified in affirming the unity, significance, goodness, value and being of one’s human existence? Only such a reality as God would make such positive affirmations possible or meaningful since man’s constant experience of limit painfully discloses his utter lack of self-sufficiency.

¹⁸*On Being a Christian*, 69.

¹⁹*Ibid.*, 70.

Before moving from the hypothesis of God to affirming that reality, Küng states that we must concede that atheism cannot be refuted on purely rational grounds. For like theism, atheism involves a basic posture and decision of the whole person. In Lonergan's language, it too is a fourth level operation. Even so there is no conclusive argument for the *necessity* of atheism, and it is concrete experiential reality itself which provides sufficient ground for assent to God's existence. But such an assent is not forced by reality or pure reason. It is grounded in a decision. When one trusts in reality as grounded and gracious or, in traditional language, "has faith in God," one does so not simply by force of pure reason, a moral postulate of practical reason or the authority or cogency of biblical testimony. All arguments for the existence of God are characterized by a decision that the meaning that one experiences has a source and ground, and this decision is characterized more by belief than by irrefutable logical steps.

To the degree that one thinks deeply and coherently about reality one sees the necessity to make a decision about its meaning. Yet an inverse ratio obtains between the profundity of certain truths and the certainty one has in affirming them. So it is that one's attitude plays such an important part in the affirmation of God. If one is to grasp the very deepest truths about oneself and the reality with which one participates, there must be a kind of propaedeutic by means of which one disposes oneself, attunes oneself intellectually and emotionally, in order to lay oneself open to the genuine certainty of a particular truth. A certain personal involvement is required for the cognitive value and force of a truly profound affirmation to be disclosed. In other words, to affirm the objective reality of God one must cultivate authentic subjectivity.

In what sense, however, can such a yielding to the seductive, hidden ground of reality be *rationally* justified? It is not rationally justified in the sense of absolute exclusivity. Atheism and agnosticism remain real options. There is no external rationality that first rigorously proves the existence of God and subsequently believes in the one affirmed. There are not two stages, one rationally guaranteeing the reality of God and the other confidently acknowledging that reality. God remains a hidden wholeness. One can only know the reasonableness of his decision by participation. If a person is not isolated but remains fully open to reality as he encounters it, he will grasp the reasonableness of his affirmation. He will discern that he is doing the most reasonable thing of all. By means of such self-involvement and a *rationabile obsequium* he *experiences* what can not be adduced by reason alone. The primal meaning, value and source of reality are disclosed to him simultaneously with his openness. Thus he can grasp the rationality of his own reason. His ultimate confidence is not irrational but the reason of reasons.

While there is no definite external rationality there is an intrinsic rationality which grounds a basic certainty. Even in the face of doubt one can grasp the rationality of his trust in God. For within the activity of adventuresome trust in God the ultimate identity, significance and value of reality become perceptible. This is more reasonable than the decision for atheism in which one goes on without knowing why one does. Systematic reflection upon the daily affirmations of value and trustworthiness in the atheist's life discloses an existential contradiction, whereas subsequent reflection upon the theistic posture of one who embraces reality as radically trustworthy discloses the ground of that confidence.

Küng is quick to point out that he does not intend his enterprise to be another instance of traditional Roman Catholic natural theology so deplored by Barth. Nor, however, does he wish to embrace an ungrounded fideism. He does not consider his discussion of God to be a kind of *preambula fidei* that will serve as the rational substructure of a later dogmatics based upon the rational arguments of pure reason. His goal is rather to evoke in the contemporary human person, taken as a whole, his concrete existence and to thematize the full implications of his existential trust in such a manner that he will grasp that the condition of the possibility of that firm trust is that God be not a hypothesis but a reality.

V. Conclusion

It is an obvious but significant fact that only those who already believe in God expend their intellectual energy attempting to demonstrate rationally that there is an objective referent to that term. And only those who consider themselves atheists expend their energies attempting to demonstrate rationally that there is no such referent. And this illuminates Lonergan's point when he says that the dynamics of religious experience or religious conversion are analogous to "falling in love." One is not asked to ground critically the conditions of the possibility for loving a particular person before one embarks on the adventure of love. And when one experiences genuine love there is a certain sense in which the experience is self-validating, self-authenticating to the participant. Nevertheless, after the fact one can make some critical statements to show the "reasonableness" of one's experience. But the world of love, like the worlds disclosed by aesthetic experiences, is available only to the participants. They are foreign lands to the detached observer.

There is a sense, of course, in which one wishes to embrace the security of Lonergan's theistic argument in *Insight*. For it vindicates one on intellectual grounds against the foe. But it is clear from Lonergan's more

recent statement that he recognized the fact that even though he worked out his argument following the strict canons of his cognitional theory (the pure detached, disinterested, unrestricted desire to know operating on the third level of consciousness), the argument was not uninfluenced by a lifetime of fourth level experiences and affects even though he had not yet thematized the notion of a fourth level in his own position.

When we turn to Küng's invitation to reflect on ourselves as a total person in a trusting response to reality we find that his point is well taken. If indeed our daily experience is marked by a trust in the radical meaning of ourselves, life, the universe, and all of reality, one may have participational understanding that this existential trust demands a metaphysical ground. This is particularly true if one has cultivated many patterns of human experience (e.g. the interpersonal, the aesthetic, the intellectual, the mystical). But of course there is the gnawing anxiety about the certainty of one's "feeling." Does not Küng's argument have the same weakness as Schleiermacher's argument from absolute dependence? Have not William James and John Dewey persuasively argued that, while many genuine experiences may be interpreted as religious, one cannot conclude with objective certitude that God is the content or agent of those experiences? This tension, however, is one that Küng recognizes and concedes. It would be resolved in part if Küng curbed the excesses of his sometimes justifiably anti-metaphysical stance.

I have not meant to suggest that we should attempt to impose artificially Hans Küng's more existential and phenomenological approach to the question of God upon Bernard Lonergan's transcendental Thomism. I have rather wanted to indicate their important but easily overlooked complementary nature. At first it appears that one starts from faith and the other starts from reason. But even if it is unthematized, the dynamic of faith is operative equally in Küng's "assumption of meaningfulness" and Lonergan's opennesses to religious experience and conversion. In this sense they are both instances of *fides quaerens intellectum*. Both Lonergan's concession of the importance of the fourth level of human consciousness for theodicy and Küng's wholistic entry into the question of God in effect embrace the Kantian as well as the existentialist insistence upon the "primacy of practical reason." Lonergan's great achievement in chapter 19 of *Insight* is as far as one can go on the third level of consciousness. To meet the valid challenges to the argument Lonergan has to acknowledge the fourth level without working out its implication. Küng, however, situates his reflections within a fourth level context with a certain amount of disdain for the rigorous intellectualism of Lonergan's third level work. However, from a close reading of Lonergan he would, I

trust, find more cogent evidence than he himself provides to demonstrate that his affirmation of the theistic ground of his concrete existence is indeed reasonable.

Langdon Gilkey has termed Lonergan's work in cognitional theory to be unsurpassed in contemporary theology. Hans Küng is justly recognized for his honest and impressive struggle with the pressing practical theological issues of the day. If, as I have suggested, there is an unexpected affinity between their respective positions on the question of knowledge of God, perhaps that uncovers a topic in need of the kind of "ongoing collaboration" for which Lonergan has eloquently pleaded.